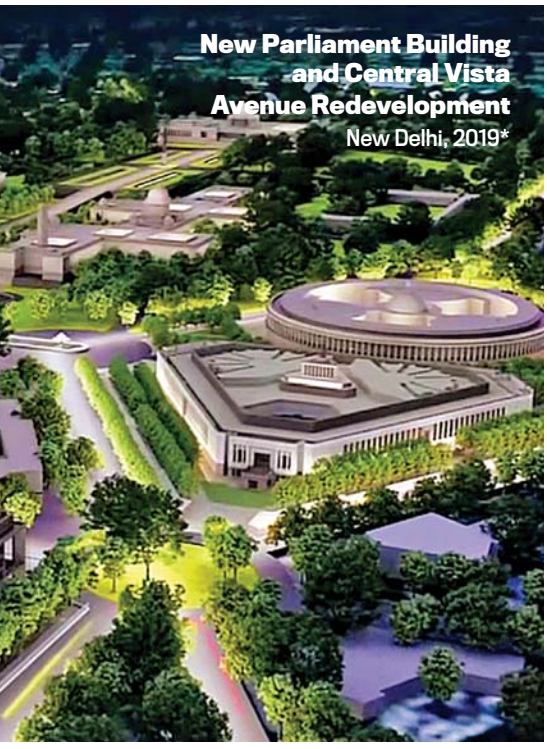
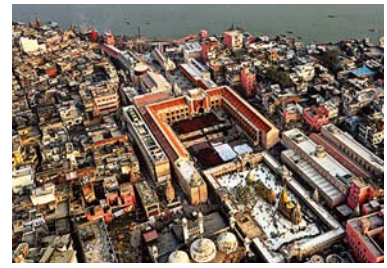


**New Parliament Building and Central Vista Avenue Redevelopment** New Delhi, 2019*



**Kashi Vishwanath Dham Corridor** Varanasi, 2014*



**Indian Institute of Management,** Ahmedabad, 2000*



**Gujarat Secretariat** Gandhinagar, 2011*



**Sabarmati Riverfront Development** Ahmedabad, 1998*

*Year of commissioning

**Through his Central Vista Project, Bimal Patel hopes to show that "India can implement high quality projects in a timely manner"**

with". In early 2020, the architect aired his views on his own career, his critics and the Central Vista commission at length in an extended and revealing first person 'conversation' in the respected architectural journal *Landscape*. Here he described his journey from his days as a Leftist student "deeply interested in the Marxist theory" and "coming under its spell", to later disillusionment, "re-educating" himself before finding his groove in "constructive engagement" with power: "If one wants to work in the public realm and design public spaces, one has to work with the government. One cannot just sit back and lament...that politicians and bureaucrats do not understand what good design is...that they have poor taste," he says in a particularly telling passage. "I try...to bridge the gap between self-appointed advocates of the public interest and those who are duly elected and appointed to take decisions in the public interest."

This approach has clearly been productive for Patel and HCP, the firm he took over from his father (the noted architect Hasmukh Patel who died in 2018). HCP's portfolio runs from bracingly modernist institutional buildings to opulently minimalist homes for the Ahmedabad elite to an impressive array of large-scale projects redesigning urban landscapes, culminating in the Central Vista project.

To his critics, Patel's candour is only further evidence of his careerist opportunism. In fact, the publication of his views in *Landscape* would provoke the journal's advisory editor to resign in protest—an early indicator of just how polarising a figure he has become. A subsequent issue featured sharp critiques of the architect from assorted luminaries, including this pithy remark from the academic Shiv Vishwanathan: "I guess his real problem is, he likes power but wants to ritually distance himself from debates and controversy. He reduces democracy to table manners in this context. His professionalism, of course, goes beyond his father's generation, but his sense of the social is restricted."

Patel, for his part, seems inured to such barbs and undaunted by the disruptions of the pandemic, let alone the attempts to halt the Central Vista project in the courts. A Supreme Court bench delivered a 2-1 decision in favour of the project in June and another petition against the construction of the vice-president's house was dismissed in November 2021. While one of the consistent objections to the entire project has been against the haste with which it has been conceived, cleared and pursued, Patel is unapologetic. In a short statement to this magazine he stated, "We are pleased the work on Central Vista is proceeding extremely well. We hope it will show that India can implement high quality projects in a timely manner." The promised deadline for completion was of course 2024, just in time for the next general elections. Timely indeed. ■